XUECHUN YU

Urban Researcher & Planner
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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Children's Park Equity; Child-Friendly & Intergenerational Planning; Environmental Justice; Spatial Analytics; GeoAI

EDUCATION

The University of Hong Kong — **Hong Kong, China**
Master of Urban Design — *Aug 2021 – Dec 2022*
Thesis: Analyzing Urban Spatial Structure of Retail Land Use Relative to Residential Land Use:
A Case Study of Hong Kong (Grade: A$^-$)
Thesis Advisor: Prof. Alain Chiaradia

Dalian University of Technology — **Dalian, China**
B.E. in Urban and Rural Planning (5-year program) — *Sep 2013 – Jun 2018*

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

GISense Lab, The University of Texas at Austin — Austin, TX, USA
Research Collaborator, GeoAI Research — *April 2026 – Present*

- Lead a research project on soundscape mapping, contributing to the lab's research on human-centered GeoAI and urban environmental sensing.
- Reproduced, fine-tuned, and evaluated multimodal models, including SounDiT, image2sound, and additional baselines, for research integrating acoustic, visual, and geospatial data.
- Contributed to drafting research project proposals in collaboration with the lab team.

China Academy of Urban Planning and Design (CAUPD), Shanghai Branch — Shanghai, China
Optimizing Urban Assessment Indicators for Child-Friendly Space Development — Dec 2024 – May 2025
Funded by UNICEF

- Investigated the integration of child-friendly spatial criteria into China's national urban assessment framework, focusing on built environment adaptations for children
- Conducted analysis of urban assessment indicator trends across multiple years, evaluating the relevance and sensitivity of existing metrics to child-friendly spatial outcomes
- Proposed an optimized indicator system incorporating age-inclusive spatial metrics, contributing to policy recommendations for UNICEF-supported urban governance reform

National Best Practices in Child-Friendly Urban Space — Oct 2024 – Jan 2025
Funded by Ministry of Housing and Urban-Rural Development (MOHURD)

- Built a nationwide case database of child-friendly spatial interventions across Chinese cities, covering parks, streets, schools, and community spaces
- Developed a multi-criteria screening and evaluation framework for identifying transferable best practices; organized expert review panels for case selection
- Synthesized core design strategies and policy innovations from selected cases into a guideline document officially released by MOHURD

Evaluation of Child-Friendly City Development in Quzhou — Aug 2024 – Feb 2025
Funded by Quzhou Women's Federation

- Designed and implemented a mixed-methods evaluation combining questionnaire surveys, field observation, indicator-based assessment, and comparative case analysis to assess the city's child-friendliness
- Conducted on-site fieldwork across multiple districts, mapping spatial conditions and user experiences in public facilities, streetscapes, and community spaces
- Produced a comprehensive visual evaluation report identifying replicable practices and policy gaps for intergenerational urban space improvement

Spatial Planning for Cross-Boundary Collaborative Zones in Shanghai Metropolitan Area Apr 2024 – Mar 2025
Funded by Shanghai Municipal Administration of Planning and Natural Resources

- Developed an evaluation framework for integrated high-quality development in cross-jurisdictional areas, drawing on international comparative case studies
- Led research on spatial optimization strategies for ecology, industry, and public service provision in the Jiading-Kunshan-Taicang border region

CONFERENCE ABSTRACTS

Yu, X. (2026). *"For a younger crowd?": Quantifying the domain-specific divergence of aging resources in gentrifying New York neighborhoods* [Conference abstract accepted]. ACSP Annual Conference.

Yu, X. (2026). *From installed to inhabited: Measuring the gap between potential and actualized affordances in children's parks through user-generated content* [Conference abstract accepted]. ACSP Annual Conference.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

China Academy of Urban Planning and Design (CAUPD), Shanghai Branch Shanghai, China
Urban Planner Apr 2023 – May 2025

- Contributed to the Shanghai Metropolitan Area Territorial Spatial Master Plan: analyzed international metropolitan trends, identified inter-city coordination needs across 14 municipalities, and designed spatial and industrial optimization strategies
- Led the cultural strategy component of the Hangzhou Internationalization Pathway Study, proposing four action plans for cultural infrastructure enhancement to support the city's global positioning
- Managed the Quzhou Child-Friendly City pilot project, coordinating satisfaction surveys, site assessments, and design interventions for six flagship intergenerational public space scenarios

Shenzhen University Institute of Urban Planning and Design Shenzhen, China
Assistant Planner Jul 2018 – Jan 2020

- Participated in the Longgang River Urban Design International Competition (awarded 2nd place), developing the initial concept proposal and coordinating with international lead designers on iterative scheme refinement
- Conducted urban positioning and industrial analysis for the Shenzhen East Station urban renewal project; researched local planning policies and design codes to inform scheme development

SELECTED CHILD-FRIENDLY PLANNING PROJECTS

Changning Yuyuan Road Child-Friendly Street Revitalization Plan Nov 2024 – Mar 2025

- Conducted walking audits and user surveys; proposed streetscape and school-route improvements informed by children's and caregivers' experiences.

Spatial Planning Guidelines for Primary and Secondary Schools, Futian District, Shenzhen Aug 2018 – Feb 2019

- Analyzed school space configurations in Hong Kong and Singapore to inform high-density planning guidelines for Shenzhen.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming & Data Analysis: Python, pandas, NumPy, Jupyter Notebook, XGBoost, SHAP

Geospatial Analysis: ArcGIS Pro, spatial data processing, spatial regression, MGWR, geovisualization

Urban Data Methods: Natural language processing, user-generated content analysis, audio preprocessing, acoustic feature extraction, multimodal data processing

Design & Visualization: Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop, InDesign, AutoCAD, Rhino, SketchUp

LANGUAGES & CERTIFICATION

Languages: Mandarin (native); English (TOEFL 100; IELTS 7.0)
Certification: Junior Engineer (certified by MOHURD)

HONORS

- Longgang River Urban Design International Competition, 2nd Place (2019)
- Innovation and Entrepreneurship Practice Award, Dalian University of Technology (2015)